CODEBOOK – CONTENT DIVERSITY IN NEWS ABOUT RISING PRICES, INFLATION AND COST OF LIVING

Should you have any questions regarding the codebook and/or coding process, please contact Elif Kılık (elif.kilik@uantwerpen.be).

Project Description

This project investigates the content diversity of news coverage around **increasing cost of living** in five countries: Belgium, Ireland, The Netherlands, The UK and Turkey. This codebook provides instructions in English for the coding of news articles in all countries. Content diversity is evaluated in terms of the variety of issue subdimensions and news actors represented in the news coverage of increasing cost of living. The analysis covers articles in the period of one year prior to the last general elections held in the country (in 2023/2024).

Selection of the Articles for Coding

The news articles were collected from NexisUni and if not available, from the websites of the news organizations. Articles are selected based on country specific and general keywords of coverage on increasing cost of living.

Access to Material and Coding Tool

The coders will be provided with the coding material collected by the researcher. The coding will be done online using Qualtrics tool. Coders can access the coding page using the link provided in the coding instructions below.

General coding rules

Consider **only** the textual information **(title, subtitles and text)** of the news article when coding, **disregard any photographs or videos, and captions belonging to photographs or videos** that may be placed in the article. When coding, **make your decisions based on the information provided in the news article and asked by the codebook, and not your own prior knowledge** or interpretations, assumed consequences or any associations that you may infer, or links to other articles. In doubt, e-mail the researcher of the project using the address provided above.

Use of Generative AI is strictly prohibited. The use of Generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, Claude, or other language models for any coding purposes is completely forbidden.

This study aims to test these models' capabilities, and the use of AI models for manual human annotations would compromise the validity and reliability of the research findings.

For each article, **start by reading the article completely at least once** before you code any variables. While coding, it is important to **always have this codebook** at hand for reference. Despite the fact that we often think we know the variables well, coding can be intensive provess and sometimes the details can be forgotten. Therefore, make sure your codebook is always open during the coding process.

Coding Instructions & Variable Descriptions

For each news article you code, go to the following Qualtrics link **for the variables M1, M2, M3, M4, V1 and V2:** https://uantwerpen.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_3NJqXK7hxrgODBQ

Section 1: Metadata

M1. Coder: Select your name from the dropdown list of coders.
M2. Article ID: Copy and paste the article ID provided in the article Word document.
M3. Article Title: Copy and paste the article title provided in the article Word document.
M4. Country: Please select the country of the news outlet provided in the article Word document.

Section 2: Article Topic

V1. Main Topic of the News Article

Does the article mainly focus on the topic **increasing cost of living**?

- Yes
- No

This variable is a filter variable used to exclude articles that are not about **increasing cost of living**from further analyses. An article is considered mainly about this topic if the **majority of its coverage** focuses on **increasing prices, cost of living pressures, or affordability problems**, either in macro-economic terms or through their impact on households.

Relevant coverage includes discussions of issues such as purchasing power, changes in wages, consumer price indices, financial living conditions, interest rates, increasing consumer prices and/or living costs (e.g. the costs of groceries, energy, fuel, rent, mortgages,

healthcare, childcare, and medical expenses), as well as poverty. Below, a more detailed list of topics falling under relevant coverage is provided.

Consider the complete article text as the unit of analysis. An article should be coded **Yes** if **at least half of its content** focuses on **increasing cost of living**. If such content constitutes approximately half of the discussion, the **title, lead, and overall framing** should be used to determine whether this topic can be considered the article's main focus. If increasing cost of living is one of two central and equally developed themes, this variable should still be coded as **Yes**.

As a guiding rule, consider the following test: **If references to increasing cost of living are removed from the article, does the core story still exist?** If yes, the article should not be coded as mainly about this topic.

Increasing cost of living is a multidimensional topic encompassing discussions about:

- **Inflation indicators:** inflation rates, statistics and forecasts, changes in consumer price indices (e.g. CPI for the UK - the name/abbreviation changes in every country but all refer to consumer price index), retail or producer price indices, general consumer price developments, and impact of inflation on increasing cost of living,
- **Causes and contributing factors of rising prices/cost of living:** government policies, global economic, political and financial developments, and changes in production or labour markets, inflation,
- **Discussion on interest rates** (e.g. mortgages, loans, credit), and its effect on household costs,
- **Impact of increasing prices/cost of living on the public in general,** including different income and demographic groups and households,
- **Purchasing power and income:** changes (increasing or decreasing) in real wages/real pays due to inflation, income inequality due to rising prices, declining purchasing power and value of savings,
- **Costs and affordability of essential goods and services** such as groceries, housing, energy (electricity, heating, gas), oil, fuel, transport, healthcare, childcare, and education,
- **Housing and mortgage costs:** costs of rent, mortgage rates, house prices, borrowing costs, interest rates on mortgage loans, property market discussions,

- **Energy prices:** price changes (increasing or decreasing) in oil, fuel, electricity and gas,
- **Poverty and other affordability problems:** People struggling to meet living costs, discussions about hunger and poverty, solutions for poverty,
- **Experiences and reactions from various groups within society** (e.g. households, workers, union members, customers) due to rising prices, affordabilty, wages, cost of living pressures in their daily/working lives, including strikes, protests, personal stories,
- **Business and organizational impact:** Effects of rising prices and inflation on business costs and operations, pricing strategies, profitability, and workforce decisions, experiences of businesses, industry, and state organizations,
- **Labor relations and pay disputes:** pay increase negotiations and wage demands, labour disputes and strikes,
- **Policy discussions/responses:** interest rate decisions, central bank policies (incl. European Central Bank for EU countries), inflation targets, and government measures addressing rising prices or living costs.

However, **brief or background mentions** of increasing cost of living **do not count** if the article is mainly about another topic (e.g. economic situation in the country (growth/recession/crisis**),** macroeconomic performance and policy (e.g. GDP, state debt), growth or recession in different sectors) where increasing prices/cost of living are discussed as context or one of the contributing factors but not discussed substantially. Such articles should only be coded ***Yes*** if the discussion is linked to increasing cost of living as **the central focus and discussed in detail in more than half of the article**.

V2. Relevance to the Country of the News Outlet

Is the discussion related to increasing cost of living-related in this article about or relevant to the country of the news outlet?

- o Yes
- o No

When coding this variable, consider only the parts of the article about increasing cost of living as the context unit and ignore the rest of the article. This variable is another filter

variable for including only increasing cost of living news coverage relevant to the country of the news outlet (as coded in variable M4 described above).